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THE TRAIN REACHES ROWGHAT: WHAT A 95-KM LINE MEANS FOR BASTAR

By **Kamlesh Bhagatkar**, *Author & Geopolitical Analyst · 14 November 2026*

On Tuesday, 20 October, a passenger train ran to Rowghat in Chhattisgarh's Kanker district. Chief Minister Vishnu Deo Sai inaugurated the 17.5-km Tadoki-Rowghat section, and Union Railway Minister Ashwini Vaishnaw joined by video from New Delhi to flag off a service between Rowghat and Raipur via Dalli-Rajhara. The Ministry of Railways called it "a historic milestone for Rowghat as rail connectivity reaches the region for the first time", according to Metro Rail News. Several reports, including News On AIR and Business Today, described it as the first train to reach Rowghat since Independence.

The new stretch completes the 95-km Dalli-Rajhara-Rowghat line, built at a cost of ₹1,628 crore, according to News On AIR, the public broadcaster's news service. Trains were already running on the first 77.5 km, from Dalli-Rajhara to Tadoki. The line is a single-track, electrified broad-gauge railway under the Raipur Division of South East Central Railway, Swarajya reported when the Commissioner of Railway Safety inspected the final section before it opened.

Beyond the FYP returned to the story in an InfoPack on 14 November. I think it deserves more attention than a ribbon-cutting usually gets, because this particular line was for years a target of Maoist opposition.

Why this line was so hard to build

To understand Rowghat, start with Bhilai. The Bhilai Steel Plant, which India Today described in 2012 as the largest and most profitable unit of the Steel Authority of India (SAIL), runs on iron ore. In July 2012, India Today reported that the Centre was worried the plant could be forced to close within three years because its existing ore source at Dalli-Rajhara was expected to run out by 2015. Rowghat was the answer. India Today put its reserves at 510 million tonnes, "sufficient to keep the plant running for decades".

The same report described why the plan was in trouble. A high-level meeting at the Union Home Ministry, attended by the Home Secretary, the Steel Secretary and Chhattisgarh's Chief Secretary and Director General of Police, took up reports "that Naxals are bitterly opposing mining in a new area called Rowghat for the Bhilai Steel Plant as well as the construction of a railway line to transport the

iron ore from Rowghat to the plant". The mining project needed deforestation over more than 2,030 hectares in Kanker and Narayanpur districts, both of which the report described as Naxal hotbeds. The state government said it had no security force to spare. The meeting decided that two battalions from the CRPF and the BSF would guard the mining area and the railway line until a dedicated force was raised.

That was 2012. The track then moved forward slowly, a few kilometres at a time. When a train first reached Antagarh, a small town in Kanker district, on 13 August 2022, The Tribune reported that two battalions of the Sashastra Seema Bal (SSB) had been guarding the project since 2016. The operational stretch was then 59 km. Only 144 tickets were sold on the first day, but a resident, Hemant Kashyap, told the paper: "It is a historic day for all of us."

From 59 km in 2022 to 77.5 km at Tadoki and now 95 km at Rowghat: by the standards of the Indian plains, that is slow progress. By the standards of a line that, according to sources quoted by India Today in 2012, no amount of security could protect inch by inch, it is a real achievement. I think the soldiers of the SSB and CRPF who stood guard over culverts and cuttings for a decade deserve to be named in any account of this line.

What the line carries

The first purpose is iron ore. Business Today and Indian Masterminds both reported that the line is expected to move ore from the Rowghat region to Bhilai. For a country that wants to make far more of its own steel, a secure ore supply for a plant of Bhilai's size matters. India Today noted in 2012 that Bhilai was then India's first and main producer of steel rails, and the sole supplier of the country's longest rail sections, 260 metres long. There is something fitting in a railway built so that a rail-making plant can keep running.

The second purpose is people. Business Today reported that residents of the area had faced transport limits that cut them off from higher education, specialised medical care, jobs and markets. Chief Minister Sai, thanking the Prime Minister and the Railway Minister on behalf of the state's three crore people, said the projects would bring "fresh impetus to industrial, commercial and socio-economic growth in remote areas", News On AIR reported. Swarajya reported that the line will also give farmers a rail route for their produce.

The project is a joint effort by the Chhattisgarh government, NMDC, SAIL and Indian Railways, according to Business Today and The Tribune. That matters because the people who need the ore and the people who run the trains share the cost.

On the same day, Sai also opened the 22-km Abhanpur-Kurud broad-gauge section, started a Raipur-Kurud service, and laid the foundation stone of an electric locomotive maintenance facility in Raipur. Vaishnaw said about ₹57,000 crore of railway work is under way in Chhattisgarh and that the state has 100 per cent railway electrification, according to Business Today and Swarajya.

The security picture has changed

The line opened in a very different Bastar from the one India Today described in 2012. On 19 May this year, Union Home Minister Amit Shah said at a press conference in Jagdalpur that Naxalism had been eradicated across the country ahead of the Centre's 31 March 2026 deadline, crediting what he called "the valour, courage and supreme sacrifice of the security forces", as reported by PTI in Telangana Today and by The Pioneer. That is the government's own assessment, and I have not seen independent data that tests it village by village. What I can say is that a passenger train running to Rowghat on a timetable is one concrete sign that the area is more open than it was.

Shah also made an argument I find persuasive. "Development could not reach these areas because Naxalism was there," he said. He said some intellectuals had argued for years that it was the other way round: that Naxalism flourished because development never arrived. The Rowghat line is a good test case. Here was a project that would have brought jobs, transport and an outlet for forest and farm produce, and the 2012 reports show that Maoists opposed it.

Shah said about 200 security camps had been set up in the Bastar division, and that nearly a third of them would be turned into "Veer Shahid Gundadhur Seva Dera", service centres meant to deliver government schemes. PTI's report put the number at about 70. If that happens, a camp that once guarded a railway site becomes a place where a family gets a ration card or a health card. I think that conversion, more than any single inauguration, will decide whether the peace in Bastar holds.

What comes after Rowghat

Rowghat is the end of the first phase. The wider plan is a line of roughly 235 to 240 km from Dalli-Rajhara through Rowghat to Jagdalpur; reports differ on the exact figure, with The Tribune giving 235 km in 2022 and Business Today giving 240 km this year. Vaishnaw said the link will be extended to Jagdalpur, and then towards Koraput in Odisha and Visakhapatnam in Andhra Pradesh, according to Metro Rail News and Business Today. If that is built, Bastar's ore and produce would have a route to an eastern port as well as to Bhilai.

I have one caution. A railway brings markets, but it also brings outsiders, land deals and mining traffic. The tribal communities of Kanker and Narayanpur have lived with conflict on their land for decades. Their consent and their share in the gains will decide whether they see this line as theirs. Shah's plan to link forest produce and dairy to cooperatives, which he described in May, points in the right direction.

The next things to watch are the first regular ore rakes from Rowghat to Bhilai, the timetable for the Rowghat-Jagdalpur stretch, and how many of the Bastar security camps actually become service centres in the coming year.

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